

The Dhāraṇī Called Supreme Compassion

Karuṇāgra-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 603 · Derge Kangyur

Toh 603 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in English as "The Dhāraṇī Called Supreme Compassion," in Sanskrit as the Karuṇāgra-nāma-dhāraṇī, and in Tibetan as Snying rje mchog ces bya ba'i gzungs. It belongs to the class of dhāraṇī literature, presenting a sacred mantra together with its accompanying liturgical framework and the spiritual and healing benefits conferred by its recitation and ritual use. The text is devoted to Avalokiteśvara, the bodhisattva of compassion described as the Lotus-Bearer who rouses beings mired in suffering, and it promises benefits ranging from the recollection of past births to the curing of leprosy in all its forms. As a dhāraṇī sūtra, it sits within the broader collection of esoteric and quasi-esoteric scriptures preserved in the Kangyur, and it opens by paying homage to the omniscient one before proceeding to reveal what it calls the supreme secret mantra of the Tathāgata.

one will come to remember one's births in all states of existence.

If one who has hands that have formed the maṇḍala massages the body with those hands, all forms of leprosy disease — the twenty-eight varieties and everything else without exception — will be pacified.

The dhāraṇī called "Supreme Compassion"

In the language of India: Karuṇāgra-nāma-dhāraṇī.

In the Tibetan language: The dhāraṇī called "Supreme Compassion."

Homage to the omniscient one.

Homage to the Lotus-Bearer (Avalokiteśvara), who holds the lotus in his hand. Homage to the arising intelligence, who perfectly rouses those sentient beings who have sunk into the dense thicket of manifold sufferings. I shall now set forth the supreme secret mantra of the Tathāgata — the arising of the pinnacle of great compassion — the siddhi of unobstructed and purposeful activity that has come forth from the mouth of the Tathāgata itself, which pacifies the karmic obscurations of the entire maṇḍala of sentient beings and the manifold sufferings of the lower states of existence, which utterly pacifies all inauspiciousness, bad omens, evil dreams, ill portents, the many kinds of disease, and the many kinds of untimely death, and which thoroughly crushes the great thousandfold world-system of negativity. I begin by first paying homage to the Blessed One, whose body is adorned with countless tens of

millions of billions of accumulations of merit.

Namo Bhagavate Vairocana-Tathāgatāya Arhate Samyaksambuddhāya, sarva
ajñāna dhakāra śamayitre. Tadyathā: sādhani sādhani, siddhi viddhāri,
bhagavate parampāra, kleśa dhavati, ajñāna śamanī śamāya, sarva pāpaṃ
viśuddha dharme nirmala jñāna gocare, asaṃga cāriṇī praśama mūrti sukha
prate, sarva kleśa dhavati, sarva pāpaṃ viśodhani, vidhyamāni vināśāni,
vināśāni, vināśāya, vināśāya, bhagavati sura-sa vimala buddhi, sara sara,
visara visara, suru suru, sūra sū, prasara prasara, visara visara,
ajvana-makoṭi-sahasra-saṅcitāna karma āpāraṇi kṣapaya, kṣema-vati
buddhapiṣāya, vaśavartini pāramitā jñāna gocare, viśeṣavati, aśeṣa mālinī,
kāraṇa gocare, mahā jñāna abhiṣeka vati, su-viniścita dharme, he he
bhagavati, mahākaruṇe kuru kuru viśodhaya māṃ, sarva satvaṃś ca,
mahākaruṇodakena sasiṅcāya, samavadhāya, sambhalāya, prarohe me,
mahākaruṇa vijana pariśuddhāya, amogha me kuru jīvita rakṣa rakṣa māṃ,
bhagavati mama mahā bodhicittaṃ sammūhyed ma santu śuddha viti mi
karuṇi, buddha bodhi prate, naraka preta tiryag-gati, duḥkhena mūlāni,
deva-manuṣya-gati, saṃvahana vigato padhackleśe,
sarva-buddha-dharma-paripūraṇi svāhā.

This dhāraṇī, called "The Supreme Compassion of the Blessed One," issued
from the uṣṇīṣa of the Blessed One. It is attended by an immeasurable
thousandfold retinue of dhāraṇīs. It destroys all misdeeds, karma, and
afflictions. It pacifies all inauspiciousness, evil dreams, ill portents, and all
forms of untimely death. It grants long life, merit, good form, strength,
happiness, confidence, and freedom from illness. It utterly vanquishes all
bhūtas (elemental spirits), forgetfulness-demons, yakṣas, rākṣasas, garuḍas,
asuras, and all kinnarī spirits. Merely by holding, hearing, or uttering the name
of this dhāraṇī, the karmic obscurations accumulated over a hundred thousand
billion lifetimes will be purified. All afflictions will be burned away. All states of
existence in the lower realms will be cut off for that person entirely.

That person will be embraced and upheld by all buddhas and bodhisattvas.
They will come to be endowed with the virtues of a bodhisattva. They will
come to possess qualities that never decline. They will never fall away from
compassion. All sentient beings will come to rejoice in them.

If one recites this seven times in each of the three periods of the day and
seven times in each of the three periods of the night, one will be freed from all
wrongdoing, and one will come to obtain immeasurable and countless

thousands of millions of bodhisattva qualities.

At dawn, having seated oneself comfortably in the cross-legged posture and formed the triangular mudrā with the hands, one directs one's attention to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas. Bringing to mind with clarity the Tathāgata as the great embodiment of all qualities, one says, "I prostrate to the Tathāgata," and having made mental prostration, if one then recites this twenty-one times, every wish and intention one holds in mind will be completely fulfilled, and one will attain accomplishment exactly as desired.

On the eighth, fourteenth, and fifteenth days of the month, one makes offerings to the Blessed One, takes the eight-fold precepts of the purification fast, dresses in white robes, makes acts of generosity, takes up the great awakening mind, and, with hands extended in an unimpeded gesture, draws a maṇḍala with one's own hands. One makes offerings of flowers of three different colors and burns white sandalwood incense. Then, mentally contemplating the various offerings and great honors fitting for the Tathāgatas throughout boundless thousands of world-realms, one presents them in thought to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas. If one then recites this great blazing quintessential dhāraṇī of the Tathāgata — the great tathāgatagarbha of the Tathāgata — until a feeling of great joy arises, one will know oneself to be dwelling in the very presence of the Tathāgatas, and will attain the joy of the Tathāgatas' great spiritual richness of Dharma, which is free from all material attachment. From that point forward, one will be born irreversibly within the lineage of the Tathāgatas. And in future lives, one will attain the great bodhisattva grounds. One will also attain the sovereignty of the great wheel-turning holder of the knowledge-mantra. One will attain dhāraṇī. One will please all the Tathāgatas. One will attain undiminished higher knowledge. In this very life, all sentient beings will come to rejoice in that person. All the gods will protect them. All nāgas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, yakṣas, and rākṣasas will also protect them, and whatever such a person speaks, those beings will act to accomplish. Whatever that person intends and sets in motion, the gods and all the rest will carry out. All that person's wishes will be completely fulfilled. No one will be able to obstruct their speech. The gods will increase that person's strength, physical beauty, merit, youthful vigor, health, and prosperity. No obstacles whatsoever will be able to hinder them.

In brief, this is for those who wish to enter the city of the Tathāgatas, those who wish to behold the great body of a Tathāgata buddha, those who wish to obtain every excellence of qualities, those who also wish to enter into the

practice of training as a great bodhisattva, those who wish to obtain the samaya of the great bodhisattva's nature of reality, those who wish to continuously and uninterruptedly, without any obstacle, realize the suchness of the great tantra,

those who wish to adorn themselves with the ornament of the Tathāgata's qualities — for all such persons, in order to accumulate the great assembly of qualities, this is praised by the Tathāgatas and properly relied upon by the bodhisattvas, the great beings. From the very outset, with great earnestness, it is to be taken up in accordance with the ritual procedure taught by all the Tathāgatas, exactly as it has been explained,

Translator's Notes

- The passage opens mid-sentence, carrying over from a preceding section. The opening clause "one will come to remember one's births in all states of existence" belongs to a benefit-enumeration list that began earlier in the text.

The dhāraṇī mantra itself is transcribed from Tibetan phonetic approximations of Sanskrit and contains several forms that are obscured or irregular due to transmission through Tibetan phonology. The mantra has been rendered as a normalized Sanskrit phonetic reconstruction based on the syllables as they appear, but some sequences remain uncertain. The phrase "siddhi viddhārī" and "buddha piṣāya" in particular are difficult to reconstruct with confidence. The overall mantra belongs to a genre of Avalokiteśvara dhāraṇī texts and the content is consistent with such literature.

The term translated as "great thousandfold world-system of negativity" renders "ston chen po rab tu 'joms pa," which more literally means "thoroughly crushing a great thousand-world-system." In context it refers to the dhāraṇī's power to overcome the vast accumulation of negative karma likened to a great three-thousandfold world-system in extent.

- The phrase rendered "great blazing quintessential dhāraṇī of the Tathāgata" translates a compound that in Tibetan reads literally "great tathāgatagarbha blazing arising." This refers to the specific dhāraṇī being praised throughout the text; the rendering preserves both the tathāgatagarbha framing and the liturgical function.

The phrase "great spiritual richness of Dharma free from material attachment" renders "zang zing med pa'i chos kyi longs spyod chen po," meaning literally "great enjoyment of Dharma without material substance," pointing to the inexhaustible, non-material abundance of the Tathāgatas' Dharma-wealth.

The final sentence is syntactically incomplete, ending in a list of aspirants introduced by "for those who wish." The passage continues in the following section.

- The passage ends mid-sentence, as it is a continuation from the preceding section and flows into the next. The phrase rendered "great assembly of qualities" reflects རྒྱུ་མཚན་ཆེན་པོ་, where རྒྱུ་མཚན་ carries its standard sense of accumulation or assembly. The instruction to take up the practice "from the very outset with great earnestness" translates རྒྱུ་མཚན་ཆེན་པོ་, where རྒྱུ་མཚན་ indicates applying oneself with vigor and intensity.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.